

# Slippery Subjects in Brazilian Portuguese

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## 1 Introduction

This paper argues that the position of canonical (pre-verbal non-*wh* DP) subjects in Brazilian Portuguese varies according to the structure in which they occur. More specifically, *Paulo* in the declarative (1a) is higher than *Paulo* in the *wh*-sentence (1b). This is depicted in (2).

- (1) a. Paulo beijou Pedro. (2) a. [CP [XP *Paulo* [YP ...  
P. kissed P.  
b. Quem (que) Paulo beijou? b. [CP [XP [YP *Paulo* ...  
who (that) Paulo kissed  
'Who did Paulo kiss?'

It has long been observed that a single projection is unable to account for the distribution of subjects cross-linguistically, and several works have advocated for the need of a fine-grained (pre-verbal) subject field (Koopman and Sportiche 1991, Cardinaletti 2004, Rizzi 2006, Rizzi and Shlonsky 2007, Shlonsky 2014, i.a.). It is also standardly assumed that each position is dedicated to a different type of subject (Cardinaletti 2004:41). My central claim is, however, that subjects of the same type – *Paulo* in (1a) and (1b) – occur in different positions depending on their structural context (hence their “slipperiness”). This proposal challenges the Subject Criterion in the sense of Rizzi 1990 and provides evidence for a particular approach to the satisfaction of EPP.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 argues that BP canonical subjects are not left-dislocated. Section 3 discusses asymmetries between subjects in declaratives and subjects in *wh*-constructions. Section 4 presents an account and some of its theoretical consequences. Section 5 revisits the asymmetries and implements analyses for them. Section 6 concludes.

## 2 BP Canonical Subjects are not Left-Dislocated

Lacerda 2020 shows that the (regular) subject position in Brazilian Portuguese (BP) can receive an aboutness topic (AT) interpretation without being left-dislocated (LD). First look at the contrast in (3), which shows that quantifier subjects can bind a possessive pronoun in the object position but cannot reconstruct for pronoun binding.<sup>1</sup>

- (3) a. Cada autor<sub>i</sub> publicou seu<sub>i</sub> melhor livro.  
each author published his best book  
'Each author published their best book.'  
b. \*[Seu<sub>i</sub> melhor livro ]<sub>k</sub> envergonhou cada<sub>i</sub> autor *t<sub>k</sub>*.  
his best book shamed each author  
'Their worst book embarrassed each author.'  
(Lacerda 2020:119)

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<sup>1</sup>Note that the subject in (3b) triggers agreement on the verb, cf. (i) below:

- (i) *Seus<sub>i</sub> melhores livros envergonharam cada autor<sub>i</sub>*  
His best books shamed.3PL each author  
'Their best books shamed<sub>(PL)</sub> each author.'

Left-periphery topics, however, do reconstruct (4). Were AT-subjects left-dislocated, we wouldn't expect (5B) to be acceptable.<sup>2</sup> (*Já* is a topic-shifting particle, used to introduce a new referent in discourse.)<sup>3</sup> I thus conclude that BP canonical subjects are not left-dislocated in cases like (1a).

- (4) [Seu pior livro], cada autor publicou *t* num ano diferente.  
 his worst book each author published in.a year different  
 'Their worst book, each author published in a different year.'  
 (Lacerda 2020:119)
- (5) A: João foi fiel em todos os seus relacionamentos.  
 J. was loyal in all the his relationships  
 'João was loyal in all of his relationships.'
- B: Já Carlos sempre foi infiel em seus relacionamentos.  
 AT C. always was unloyal in his relationships  
 'As for Carlos, he was always unloyal in his relationships.'

### 3 Subject/Subject Asymmetries

Even though the subjects in (1a) and (1b) are not left-dislocated, they do not pattern alike. This section presents some of the asymmetries attested between canonical subjects of declaratives and canonical subjects of *wh*-sentences.

#### 3.1 Ellipsis

In cases of sentential conjunction, ellipsis of the second conjunct under a stranded negation following the subject is allowed in BP: (6a) shows the full (non-elided) version of the conjunction, whereas (6b) depicts the possible deletion. Ellipsis, however, is not allowed in a *wh*-construction under the same conditions (7). Although conjoining *wh*-sentences is possible (7a), deletion is not allowed (7b).

- (6) a. A atriz beijou o fã, mas o ator não o beijou.  
 the actresskissed the fan but the actor not him kissed  
 'The actress kissed the fan but the actor didn't.'
- b. A atriz beijou o fã, mas o ator não.  
 the actress kissed the fan but the actor not  
 'The actress kissed the fan but the actor didn't.'
- (7) a. Quem a atriz beijou e quem o ator não beijou?  
 who the actress kissed and who the actor not kissed  
 'Who did the actress kiss and who did the actor didn't kiss?'
- b. \*Quem a atriz beijou e quem o ator não?  
 who the actress kissed and who the actor not  
 'Who did the actress kiss and who did the actor didn't?'

Considering that the subject and the negation stand in a Spec-Head relation, argued to be a condition on ellipsis (Saito and Keiko 1990, Lobeck 1995), we capture these facts by taking the subject and the negation to be in the relevant Spec-Head relation only in (6), but crucially not in (7). It would then naturally follow that the negation heads different projections in (6–7).

#### 3.2 Quantifier Float

Note the contrast that arises between BP floating quantifiers in (8–9). In view of the stranding approach to quantifier float, where it is argued that the DP raises to another Spec, leaving the quantifier stranded below, we can easily capture the contrast if the position to which the DP moves to in (8b)

<sup>2</sup>Also note that the AT-subject controls agreement on the auxiliar and that there is no intonational break following the subject.

<sup>3</sup>Importantly, AT-subjects are necessarily D-linked, which has been argued to crucially distinguish LD topics from canonical subjects (Rizzi 2006, 2018; subjecthood is not affected by topichood in his sense).

is not available in (9b), thus showing that the subjects in (8a) and (9a) don't land in the same position and that the former must be higher than the latter.

- (8) a. [Todos os alunos] são amados pela Maria.  
all the students are loved by.the M.  
'All the students are loved by Maria.'
- b. [Os alunos] são [todos t] amados pela Maria.  
the students are all loved by.the M.  
'All the students are loved by Maria.'
- (9) a. Por quem [todos os alunos] são amados?  
by whom all the students are loved  
'By whom are all the students loved?'
- b. ??/\*Por quem [os alunos] são [todos t] amados?  
by whom the students are all loved

### 3.3 Adverb Placement

Canonical BP subjects also behave differently regarding adverb placement depending on the clause type. Consider (10) and (11). In a declarative the sentential adverbial PP *de fato* 'indeed' occurring between the subject and the verb takes scope over the proposition, and when it follows the verb (preceding the object DP), it takes scopes over the DP, giving rise to a contrastive topic reading.

- (10) a. A Maria de fato viu o João.  
the M. of fact saw the J.  
'It was indeed the case that Maria saw João.'
- b. A Maria viu de fato o João.  
the M. saw of fact the J.  
'It was indeed João that Maria saw.'

In a *wh*-construction, however, only the contrastive topic reading is available when the PP occurs between the subject and the verb, patterning with the post-verbal PP in (10b) rather than with the preverbal one in (10a), which is a new empirical observation.

- (11) a. Quem a Maria de fato viu (ontem)?  
who the M. of fact saw yesterday  
(for which *x*, it was indeed *x* that Maria saw *x*?)  
(\*for which *x*, it was indeed the case that Maria saw *x*?)
- b. Quem a Maria viu de fato (ontem)?  
who the M. saw of fact yesterday  
(for which *x*, it was indeed *x* that Maria saw *x*?)

Considering that sentential adverbs are fixed in the clause (Chomsky 1993, Cinque 1999), if *a Maria* were in the same position in both (10a) and (11a), the contrast would be unaccounted for. I thus propose the following: that the reading in which the adverbial phrase out-scopes the proposition is available even when the subject precedes it indicates that the subject is higher in (10) than in (11).

### 3.4 Post-verbal Subjects

The distribution of post-verbal subjects is also relevant here. Verbs like *importar* ('matter') for instance, do not allow post-verbal subject constructions:<sup>4</sup>

<sup>4</sup>Post-verbal subjects are usually available in BP for unaccusative constructions with verbs like e.g., *chegar* ('arrive'); (12c) is felicitous if the PP is assigned a contrastive topic reading, irrelevant here.

(i) a. *A carta chegou.* (lit. 'The letter arrived.')  
b. *Chegou a carta.* (lit. 'Arrived the letter.')

- (12) a. Essa causa importa pro ativista.  
           This cause matters to.the activist  
       b. \*Importa essa causa pro ativista.  
           matters this cause to.the activist  
       c. \*Pro ativista importa essa causa.  
           to.the activist matters this cause  
           ‘This cause matters to the activist.’

Interestingly, the post-verbal position is available for the subject in *wh*-constructions (13). Assuming that the post-verbal subject constructions like in (12) instantiate verb movement to a position right above the subject, the fact that declaratives disallow such verb fronting thus suggests a structural asymmetry between the pre-verbal subjects.

- (13) a. Pra quem [essa causa] importa?  
           to whom this cause matters  
           ‘The mistakes of the government interest the corrupt politics.’  
       b. Pra quem importa [essa causa]?  
           to whom matters this cause  
           ‘To whom does this cause matter?’

### 3.5 Locative Inversion

It has been argued that external arguments can be post-verbal in BP unergative constructions if a locative PP occurs in subject position (Spec,TP in Avelar and Cyrino 2018); see also Avelar 2009 and Lacerda 2020, in which case the verb surfaces with a third-person singular inflection.

- (14) a. Várias pessoas dormiram naquele quarto.  
           several people slept.3PL in.that bedroom  
           ‘Several people slept in that bedroom.’  
       b. Naquele quarto dormiu várias pessoas.  
           in.that bedroom slept.3SG several people  
           ‘Several people slept in that bedroom.’

An argument for the subjecthood of such locatives concerns the fact they don’t reconstruct for pronoun binding (15a), but do when left-dislocated (15b) – the same contrast discussed for (3) and (4).

- (15) a. \*Na sua<sub>i</sub> empresa trabalha muitos empresários<sub>i</sub>.  
           in.the his company works many businessmen  
           ‘In their company, many businessmen work.’  
       b. Na sua<sub>i</sub> empresa, muitos empresários<sub>i</sub> trabalham.  
           in.the his company many businessmen work  
           ‘In their company, many businessmen work.’

Now consider the contrast in (16–17). Again, if subjects were to occur in the same position in both declaratives and *wh*-constructions in BP, there would be no reason locative inversion should be disallowed in (17b) given that the PP goes to the (canonical) subject position.

- (16) a. Várias pessoas dormiram naquele quarto.  
           several people slept.3PL in.that bedroom  
           ‘Several people slept in that bedroom.’  
       b. Naquele quarto dormiu várias pessoas.  
           in.that bedroom slept.3SG several people  
           ‘Several people slept in that bedroom at night.’

- (17) a. Quantas            pessoas        dormiram    naquele        quarto?  
           how.many        people        slept.3PL    in.that        bedroom  
           ‘How many people slept in that bedroom?’  
       b. \*Quantas            pessoas        naquele        quarto        dormiu?  
           how.many        people        in.that        bedroom        slept.3SG  
           ‘How many people slept in that bedroom?’

### 3.6 Aboutness-Topic Subjects One More Time

In view of the fact that AT-subjects are not necessarily left-dislocated (section 1), the impossibility in (18B') highlights an additional asymmetry, which is that no AT-topics are allowed under *wh*-questions.<sup>5</sup>

- (18) A: O            Pedro leu dez livros do Chomsky pra esse curso.  
           The P. read ten books of.the Chomsky to this course  
           ‘Pedro read ten books from Chomsky to this course.’  
       B: Já o João leu o quê?  
           AT the J. read what  
       B': \*O que já o João leu?  
           what AT the J. read  
           (Lacerda 2020:27)

### 3.7 Local Subject Resumption

It has been argued that local subject resumption (LSR) does not involve left-dislocation (cf. Pontes 1987, Quarezemin 2020, Kriek 2021, 2022). Here is an argument. (19b) below can be uttered with a falling intonation typically associated with declarative constructions (19a). It can also be uttered as in (19c), where the subject DP *o menino* preceding the pronoun has a rising intonation, usually preceded by a pause, and the remaining chunk is uttered with a falling intonation. Note that (19b) is felicitous in an out-of-the-blue context, e.g., it can be uttered at the start of a phone call: *Alô, o João ele tá em casa?* (lit. ‘Hello, the João he is in home?’).

- (19) a. O menino cozinha bem.            ↓  
           ‘The boy cooks well.’  
       b. O menino ele cozinha bem.            ↓  
           ‘The boy he cooks well.’  
       c. O menino ↑ ele cozinha bem.            ↓  
           ‘The boy, he cooks well.’

Note that object topicalization (OT) requires a rising-falling intonation (20). Additionally, OT disallows a quantified expression, which is possible under LSR (21).

- (20) a. A sopa ↑ o menino cozinhou (ela).            ↓  
           ‘The soup, the boy cooked it.’  
       b. \*A sopa o menino cozinhou (ela).            ↓  
       (21) a. Cada criança<sub>i</sub> ela leva seu<sub>i</sub> livro pra escola.  
           each child she takes her book to.the school  
           ‘Each child brings her (own) book to school.’  
       b. \*Cada criança<sub>i</sub> eu vi em sua<sub>i</sub> escola.  
           each child I saw in her school  
           ‘I saw each child in her school.’

<sup>5</sup>(18B') is independently ruled out in Lacerda 2020 who claims that topics must always be sentence-initial, a claim we do not have to follow here.



it follows that the EPP must be satisfied there in such cases (whereas a regular DP subject as in Mary left would satisfy the EPP in Spec,IP).<sup>8</sup>

I then propose that BP regular subjects are in Spec,A/A'P in declarative sentences, whereas BP regular subjects are in Spec,IP in *wh*-sentence. This is depicted in (25).

- (25) a. [CP [A/A'P *Paulo* [IP *beijou João*.  
 b. [CP *Quem (que)* [A/A'P [IP *Paulo* *beijou?*

The crucial claim here is that *Paulo* in (25a) is higher than *Paulo* in (25b). Evidence for BP regular subjects not occupying Spec,IP is below.<sup>9</sup> Lasnik and Saito 1994 have observed that extraction out of a topic (26b) is better than extraction out of the subject position (26a) in English. In BP there is no such contrast - both are crudely unacceptable in BP (27).

- (26) a. ?\*who do you think [pictures of t] are on sale?  
 b. ??who do you think [pictures of t], John wanted?  
 (Lasnik and Saito 1994:101)
- (27) a. \*de quem você acha que [as fotos t] estão na promoção?  
           of whom you think that the pictures are on sale  
 b. \*de quem você acha que [as fotos t], o João queria?  
           of whom you think that the pictures the J. wanted

If the subject were in Spec,IP like in English, we would expect an amelioration effect in (27a), contrary to fact. Not being in Spec,CP either, BP subjects must then be in the Spec of A/A'P.

There are different proposals in the literature for a mixed A/A' (e.g. van Urk 2015, Lohninger et al. 2022). The main motivation to adopt Bošković 2024's view regards his contextual approach to the EPP. The author argues that the EPP can be satisfied in different positions (Spec,IP in *Mary left*, Spec,A/A'P in *Who left?*). More specifically, EPP is argued to be satisfied in the highest projection available in a domain – the EPP domain, which in his system includes A/A'P. Crucially, the locus of EPP is not fixed. In view of the discussion above, it should be clear how such approach is desired: the fact that subjects may occupy different positions depending on the structure they are in has no issue on the satisfaction of the EPP. In BP, subjects satisfy EPP in Spec,A/A'P in declaratives, but in Spec,IP in *wh*-constructions. Consequently, this study also challenges the proposal that regular subjects move to a criterial position (in the sense of Rizzi 1990); see Rizzi and Shlonsky 2006 and Rizzi 2018, who imply that subject movement always targets the same Spec as a landing site. (The EPP is there seen as a criterion effect on par with focus and topic criteria). We have seen several cases that are incompatible with a unique subject landing position.

## 5 Accounting for the Asymmetries

The proposal that subjects in declaratives and subjects in *wh*-sentences occupy different structural positions allows us to lay out accounts for the asymmetries presented above. Although different particular implementations could be pursued, the crucial point being made here is that any account should refer to the subjects being in specifiers of different projections.

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The *wh*-subject in (ia) patterns with the *wh*-object in (ic) rather than with the DP subject in (ib) in that it allows a floating quantifier. If *who* were in Spec,IP (or if were to move through it), we would expect (ia) to be bad on a par with (ib), which shows that the quantifier cannot be stranded under movement to IP.

<sup>8</sup>It is argued that this position is not exclusive of local *wh*-subjects, but also the position for V2-subjects in Germanic languages, *only*-subjects, overt imperative subjects, locative inversion, CP-subjects, *there*-subjects (as in *There arrived a woman at the station*), Singlish non-agreeing subjects, Defaka focus subjects, and Chinese/Japanese subjects.

<sup>9</sup>See Dias 2022 for discussion on the mixed A and A' properties of BP subjects, such as (A): idiom preservation under (hyper-)raising, absence of weak cross over effects (Fong 2018), ability to host negative quantifier; (A'): discourse effects, block inverse scope (as in *who loves everyone?*), among others.

### 5.1 Ellipsis Revisited

A Spec-head relation has been argued to be a necessary condition in the licensing of ellipsis (Saito and Keiko 1990, Lobeck 1995). Along these lines, subject stranding ellipsis (cf. 6) may only be allowed when the subject is in Spec,A/A'P. Ellipsis in (28b) is therefore disallowed because the subject in Spec,IP is not involved in the relevant relation.

- (28) a. [A/A'P *o ator não*] [IP <*beijou o fã na rua*>  
 b. \*[CP *quem*] [IP *o ator não* <*beijou na rua*> ?

### 5.2 Quantifier Float Revisited

The facts in (8–9) can be taken to imply that moving subjects stranding quantifiers target a higher position, i.e., Spec,A/A'P instead of Spec,IP. It is still a mystery why a lower subject shouldn't allow for a floating quantifier, but were the subjects in (29a–b) in the same position, such an asymmetry couldn't even be stated.

- (29) a. [A/A'P *os alunos<sub>i</sub>*] [IP *são todos <sub>t<sub>i</sub></sub> amados pela Maria*.  
 b. ??/\*[CP *por quem*] [IP *os alunos<sub>i</sub> são todos <sub>t<sub>i</sub></sub> amados?*

### 5.3 Adverb Placement Revisited

Taking the adverbial PP *de fato* in (10) to be an IP adjunct, we can easily accommodate the asymmetry below: (30b) is bad because *de fato* is not IP-adjoined.

- (30) a. [A/A'P *a Maria (de fato)*] [IP *viu o João*  
 b. [CP *quem*] [IP *a Maria (\*de fato) viu ?*

### 5.4 Post-verbal Subjects Revisited

Assuming the verb moves to the head of A/A'P,<sup>10</sup> the unavailability of post-verbal subjects in declaratives (12,13) in such cases is accounted for simply because verbs can't move that high, i.e., above the subject in Spec,A/A'P. Since the subject is lower in Spec,IP in *wh*-sentences, the verb can surface pre-verbally (14–15).

### 5.5 Locative Inversion (LI) Revisited

Bošković 2024 argues that locative inversion in English targets Spec,A/A'P, which is able to host non-nominal subjects, contrary to IP. I extend this analysis to BP, with the difference that in BP both LI and regular subjects go to Spec,A/A'P (and in the case of the former, they must). A nice consequence of this approach is that it enables us to unify BP with English in this respect.

- (31) a. [A/A'P *PP<sub>i</sub>*] [IP  
 b. [CP *Qu-*] [IP *\*PP<sub>i</sub>*

### 5.6 Aboutness-Topic Subjects Revisited

This one is straightforward. Since AT-subjects surface in Spec,A/A'P, they are disallowed in *wh*-sentences because they must be lower in Spec,IP.

- (32) a. [A/A'P *JÁ DP*  
 b. \*[CP *Qu-*] [IP *JÁ DP*

<sup>10</sup>See Martins 2013 for arguments that verbs in BP may raise to a position above IP.

## 5.7 LSR Revisited

Finally, an account for local subject resumption can be delineated. Considering resumptives surface in Spec,IP, with the DP subject in Spec,A/A'P, they become unavailable in *wh*-sentences because the DP subject is already in Spec,IP blocking resumption.

- (33) a.  $[_{A/A'P} \text{ a Maria}]_{IP} \text{ ela viu o João}$   
 b.  $*[_{CP} \text{ quem}]_{IP} \text{ a Maria ela viu}$

## 6 Conclusion

In this paper I have claimed that canonical subjects in BP vary their position in the clause depending on the structure in which they occur. More specifically, subjects in declarative sentences are higher than subjects in *wh*-sentences. I have identified the higher subject position as Bošković 2024's Spec,A/A'P, which has allowed us to characterize the asymmetries and still account for the fact that BP regular subjects are neither left-dislocated, nor in Spec,IP. It also provides support for a contextual approach to the satisfaction of EPP, contra a single locus for the EPP.

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